

# Societal Challenge Report: Supermarket Food Waste

## News report description

“The scandal of food waste - and how we can stop it” was written by Julian Baggini on the 8th of October 2024 in The Guardian - an internationally recognized British daily newspaper and news publicator.

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## The scandal of food waste – and how we can stop it

Every informed observer agrees that food waste and loss must be reduced if we are to feed all humans. What’s stopping us?

By [Julian Baggini](#)

In traditional societies, little to no food goes to waste. Every edible part of an animal or plant is utilised. Researchers found that the members of a Maasai cattle herding community in northern Tanzania were outraged at the thought of intentionally wasting food, calling those who would do so “lunatics”. Some even said it was worse than killing a person, because murder leads to one death, whereas wasting food could result in several.

Attitudes towards waste are very different in industrialised nations. The United Nations Environment Programme (Unep) estimates that 17% of total global food production is wasted and around the same amount lost, meaning that around a third of food produced is not consumed. The global average for household waste is 74kg per person annually, and this figure is broadly similar for lower-, middle- and high-income countries.

In addition to food waste, there is also food loss: crop and livestock commodities destined for human consumption which are discarded before

## Describe the challenge identified in this news article in your own words.

The article talks about two main points: food waste, and food loss.

One of the first main claims that the article makes is that there exists enough food that could feed the populace; however, a big issue lies in the distribution and cost of this food. The article then proceeds by explaining reasons why farmers have issues with such distribution (e.g retailers, wholesalers etc, which require larger quantities than they buy). Here, it is also emphasised that retail culture encourages bulk purchasing through the employment of bulk discounts. All these products, however, do not end up getting used by the consumer.

Then, the article proceeds to write about possible ways of decreasing food waste (i.e decreasing bulk buys, or getting better packaging to make the product more attractive). However, it also discusses the ideas of downsides. For example, how the well-intentioned app “Too Good To Go” started to become a ‘sales channel’. Moreover, even though we may want to use ‘recyclable’ material a lot of it still doesn’t end up as ‘recycled’. Showcasing a link between food waste, and packaging waste.

The article ends with a note that we should make food waste - and the individuals, retails etc. - more visible. This should mainly be done by ‘carefully’ designed regulations.

**a. Why are you interested in this topic?**

Food waste has a great impact on the world in many ways that we don’t see. Inadvertently, food waste contributes to many major global issues. For example, food waste is associated with 8-10% of all global greenhouse emissions (Julian Baggini, 2024).

Many factors affect food waste, with leading issues being lack of accessibility (low distribution) and high costs (Julian Baggini, 2024). All these factors lead to larger amounts of food being lost/wasted throughout the world.

Instead of the food being wasted by supermarkets, households, and restaurants it could be redistributed to the population. Creating a food waste database therefore would be beneficial to decreasing overall retail food waste.

Overall, reducing food waste is an important factor in reducing global greenhouse emissions.

**b. For whom is this challenge relevant (who are your stakeholders)?**

Food Waste concerns affect a wide range of stakeholders. The biggest categories include:

1) Government - The EU government is actively trying to reduce food waste (with a goal of reducing 30% retail food waste and 10% of food processing waste). With a detailed breakdown plan for food waste reduction, and achievements in 2030 (*Food Waste in Europe*, 2024).

2) Consumers - Majority of the consumers spend money on food they do not end up consuming, thus wasting it. They are also impacted by the greenhouse gas emissions which result from food waste..

3) Food Banks - Food banks could benefit from a “circular economy” and “platform based system” to redistribute food (Gál et al., 2025).

4) Supermarkets - Supermarkets are directly involved in food waste through decisions about ordering, stocking, disposing of food etc.

5) Suppliers - Suppliers care about the amount of food they have to distribute. Moreover, they care about the amount being bought.

## **Peer reviewed articles**

### Article 1:

This article directly connects to our societal question, by investigating food waste in the supermarket. This is primarily discussed through the employees perspective by looking at the fresh produce department - the most common department for food waste. By demonstrating that in store workers are critical decision makers in what gets culled, discounted or thrown away rather than looking at macro or household levels. The article categorizes causes of and solutions to food waste into four operational themes: Policy, Practice, People, Product .While noticing why generic food reduction strategies tend to fail.

### Citation

Mattsson, L., & Williams, H. (2022). Avoidance of Supermarket Food Waste—Employees’ Perspective on Causes and Measures to Reduce Fruit and Vegetables Waste. *Sustainability*, 14(16), 10031. <https://doi.org/10.3390/su141610031>

Subtype : Original Article

### Article 2:

A study done on avoidable food waste in Finland shows why and how food waste across different sectors such as food services, households, retail, etc, happens. All information provided also explains the different consequences that follow (e.g. greenhouse gas emissions, loss of money, etc) and how they impact the population as a whole. The study also breaks down the problem into subcategories, such as: type of food wasted, reason for disposal, and sector, which helps to show where changes could be made in order to reduce the waste.

Citation: Katajajuuri, J.-M., Silvennoinen, K., Hartikainen, H., Heikkilä, L., & Reinikainen, A. (2014). Food waste in the Finnish food chain. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, 73, 322–329. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jclepro.2013.12.057>

Subtype: Original Article

#### Article 3:

Gál et al. (2025) discusses how food waste has been investigated from 2019-2024, highlighting its increase throughout the years and possible causes and solutions. It gives an overview of the fact that food waste leads to both climate issues but is also a socioeconomic problem which directly links to our topic of interest.

Citation: Gál, T., Kovács, S., & Buglyó-Nyakas, E. (2025). A comprehensive analysis of food waste through historical context: A bibliometric study from 2019 to 2024. *Cleaner Waste Systems*, 11, 100318. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.clwas.2025.100318>

Subtype: Review Article

#### Article 4:

This article explores supermarkets' food waste, specifically looking into a case study of Thailand, Bangkok. It discusses specific data points of abbreviated supermarkets A and B, and how much food waste each one produces, and how they deal with it. It also explores different aspects in supermarkets that affect the amount of food waste produced: Management Practices, Stakeholder Perspectives, and Policy Relevance toward Sustainability. Overall, the article gives a well-rounded view of approaches to food waste in different supermarkets, legal frameworks, and general interviews with stakeholders (e.g. Branch Staff, District Officers, and Private Landwaste Processors).

Citation: Karpkerd, P., Fukuda, S., & Muangthong-on, T. (2026). Exploring Supermarket Food Waste: Management Practices, Stakeholder Perspectives, and Policy Relevance toward Sustainability. *ACS Environmental Au*. <https://doi.org/10.1021/acsenvironau.5c00226>

Subtype: Original article

#### References:

*Food waste in Europe: Facts, EU policies and 2030 targets*. (2024, March 20). Topics | European Parliament.

<https://www.europarl.europa.eu/topics/en/article/20240318STO19401/food-waste-in-europe-facts-eu-policies-and-2030-targets>

Julian Baggini. (2024, October 8). *The scandal of food waste – and how we can stop it* | *Food waste* | *The Guardian*. The Guardian.

[https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2024/oct/08/the-scandal-of-food-waste-and-how-we-can-stop-it?](https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2024/oct/08/the-scandal-of-food-waste-and-how-we-can-stop-it?hpid=hp-top-stories%3Aenvironment%3Ahomepage%2Fstory&hpid=hp-top-stories%3Aenvironment%3Ahomepage%2Fstory)